than during the winter, in the summer the hours were longer, and the hours were shorter in wintertime.

Sundials, hourglasses, and water clocks already existed in the ancient world, in the Mediterranean region and in China—but they did not play the cruel role that clocks do today in the organization of our lives. It is only in the fourteenth century in Europe that people's lives start to be regulated by mechanical clocks. Cities and villages build their churches, erect bell towers next to them, and place a clock on the bell tower to mark the rhythm of collective activities. The era of clock-regulated time begins.





Gradually, time slips from the hands of the angels and into those of the mathematicians—as is graphically illustrated by Strasbourg Cathedral, where two sundials are surmounted, respectively, by an angel (one inspired by earlier sundials from 1200) and by a mathematician (on the sundial put there in 1400).

The usefulness of clocks supposedly resides in the fact that they tell the same time. And yet this idea is also more modern than we might imagine. For centuries, as long as travel was on horseback, on foot, or in carriages, there was no reason to synchronize clocks between one place and another. There was good reason for *not* doing so. Midday is, by definition, when the sun is at its highest. Every city and village had a sundial that registered the moment the sun was at its midpoint, allowing the clock on the bell tower to be regulated